

Towards a Proposition Approach for Exclusives in Kasem

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1. Introduction

The syntax-semantic properties of the exclusive focus sensitive particle *only* have been a subject of debate for some time now. Syntactically, *only* can adjoin to different positions in the clause. It can occur in a pre-verbal position away from its focus associate (1-a) & (2-a). It can also adjoin directly to its focus associate as in (1-b) & (2-b). Both cases have been called *adverbial-only* and *adfocal-only* respectively.¹

- (1) a. John **only** bought A CANDY .
b. John bought **only** A CANDY .
- (2) a. [_{TP} John [_{VP} **only** [_{VP} ⟨John⟩ bought [_{DP} a candy_F]]]]
b. [_{TP} John [_{VP} ⟨John⟩ bought [_{DP} **only** [_{DP} a candy_F]]]]

Semantically, on the other hand, *only* composes with a proposition as in (3), from Hirsch (2019: 2) based on Horn (1969) and Rooth (1985).² This means that the proposition which *only* composes with is true iff other alternative propositions are false. The focus associate of *only* indicates the presence of alternatives (Krifka 2008), and these alternatives are either sub-constituents of a sentence or the whole sentence itself, depending on the focus.

- (3) **only**^{ALT} = $\lambda p_{st} . \lambda w : p(w) . \forall p' \in \text{ALT}[p'(w) \rightarrow p \subseteq p']$

Adverbial-*only* cases fall within the purview of *only*'s compositional semantics with a proposition because it takes scope over the vP/VP, which can be classified as a form of proposition. Adfocal-*only* on the other hand, poses a challenge to the semantics of *only* given above. This is because *only* adjoins to a DP rather than a VP, as in (2-b) above. This difference in behaviour has led to the proposition of two distinct semantics for *only* (Rooth 1985, 1992): one in which *only* composes with a proposition (the original meaning of *only*), and a second one which involves the type-shifting of *only* in order to be able to compose with the focused DP, forming a quantifier XP in the process (cf. Hirsch 2022, Hirsch & Wagner 2019).

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¹ This is not only peculiar to DP arguments. When a PP or even an adverb is the focus associate, adverbial-*only* remains in the fixed position before the verb (i-a) & (ii-a). The adfocal-*only* adjoins to the focus associates directly (i-b) & (ii-b).

- (i) a. John **only** put a candy ON THE TABLE.
b. John put a candy **only** ON THE TABLE.
- (ii) a. John **only** bought a candy YESTERDAY.
b. John bought a candy **only** YESTERDAY.

² As far as I know, Horn (1969) was the first person to propose a propositional analysis for *only* (and *even*).

$$(4) \quad \text{only}_Q^{ALT} = \lambda Q_{est,st} . \lambda f_{est} . \text{only}(Q(f))$$

However, there have been a line of cross-linguistic studies which argue for a uniform treatment of *only* across board. Such studies include Bassi et al. (2022), Bayer (1996, 2018, 2020), Branen & Erlewine (2023), Hirsch (2019, 2022), Hirsch & Wagner (2019), Lee (2005), Quek & Hirsch (2017), and Sun (2021), among others. All these studies directly or indirectly push for the treatment of *only* as a pure proposition operator. In other words, there is no need for another meaning of *only*. The proposition meaning of *only* can account for adfocal-*only* cases as well. All we need to do is to assume a bipartite analysis for the adfocal-*only* cases whereby the exclusive interpretation comes from a high exclusive null operator while the adfocal-*only* itself is semantically inert (as an agreement morpheme) (Branen & Erlewine 2023, Hirsch 2022, Lee 2005, Sun 2021, Yip to appear).³ This is called the *Proposition Approach* by Bassi et al. (2022).⁴ The second approach adopts (4) which involves the quantifier-raising of both the adfocal-*only* and the focus associate (which have now formed a single quantifier phrase). This is the *Quantifier-Raising Approach* (cf. Bassi et al. 2022, Hirsch 2022). Therefore, taking example (5) as a reference, the proposition approach proposes the structure in (6) while the quantifier-raising approach proposes the LF structure in (7), respectively.

(5) John bought **only** [a CANDY].

(6) Proposition Approach:

$[_{TP} \text{ John Op}_{[iEXCL]} [_{VP} \text{ bought } [_{VP} \dots [_{DP} \text{ only}_{[uEXCL]} [_{DP} \text{ a CANDY}]]]]]$

(7) Quantifier Approach:

LF: $[_{TP} \text{ John}_i [_{VP} [_{QP} \text{ only } [_{DP} \text{ a candy}_F]]] [_{VP} \text{ t}_i \text{ bought } [_{QP} \text{ only } [_{DP} \text{ a candy}_F]]]]]$

This study contributes to the debate from a morphosyntactic focus marking language, Kasem. Kasem is a Mabia (Gur) language spoken in the Upper East Region of northern Ghana and Burkina Faso by about 250,000 speakers (Jeckel et al. 2024). Using semantic, syntactic and morphological tests, I argue for a proposition approach for Kasem's adfocal-*only* cases. Kasem is particularly interesting because it offers a clear case of morphological focus marking both in the in-situ and ex-situ positions as we will see soon. Such overtness in focus marking makes the focus associate easily recognisable, unlike the prosodic focus marking languages. Overall, the study offers a cross-linguistic support for the proposition approach and further contributes to the ongoing debate on the best approach for analysing adfocal-*only*.

The paper is organized as follows: section 2 begins with a description of the focus marking system in Kasem. After that, the data on the adfocal exclusive focus sensitive particle *yerane* 'only' is described. With the data in place, in section 3 I provide some arguments in support of the proposition approach in Kasem. A bipartite (concord) analysis is provided to account for the theoretical assumptions in section 4. While in section 5, a brief discussion on backward association with adverbial-*only* is given. Section 6 concludes the paper and gives direction for further research.

2. Describing focus and association with *exclusives* in Kasem

2.1. Focus construction

Kasem is an S(TAM)VO language (8) which marks focus morphosyntactically. The focus constituent is followed by an obligatory focus particle *mo* in both the in-situ position (9-b) and ex-situ position (9-c).⁵ *Mo* is also obligatory in *wh*-questions (9-a). The focus associate in (9) is the direct object which forms a constituent with the focus particle.

³ See Yip & Adedeji (to appear), however, for a quantifier-particle approach to exclusive doubling where they argued that the adfocal exclusive particle in Yorùbá is the exclusive quantifier while the adverbial particle is a scope-marking particle which indicates the (c)overt movement of the adfocal particle with the focus.

⁴ This has also been given different names such as *concord* (Hirsch 2019, 2022), *bipartite analysis* (Bayer 1996, Sun 2021), *operator-particle approach* (Bayer 2018, 2020, Branen & Erlewine 2023), etc.

⁵ For the notations employed in this paper, both the focus particle and the focus sensitive particle will be in **bold**. The focus associate will be put inside an F-marked square bracket $[XP]_F$. In the corresponding English translation, the focus associate (not necessarily the part with the pitch accent) will be in SMALL CAPS.

- (8) Adam yaa go chworō.
Adam PST kill fowl
'Adam slaughtered a fowl.'
- (9) a. Bε ***(mo)** Adam ke diim?
what FOC Adam do yesterday
'What did Adam do yesterday?'
- b. Adam go [chworō]_F ***(mo)** diim.
Adam kill fowl FOC yesterday
'Adam slaughtered A FOWL yesterday.'
- c. [Chworō]_F ***(mo)** Adam go diim.
fowl FOC Adam kill yesterday
'It was A FOWL that Adam slaughtered yesterday.'

The constituency of the focus associate and the focus particle is supported by the fact that *mo* also follows adjunct focus as in (10). In fact, time adverbials in Kasem adjoin freely in the preverbal position and can host the focus particle (11); another evidence for the constituency of *mo* and the focus associate. It is important to state here that the preverbal occurrence of the time adverbial is not tied to focus. It can occupy the same position in a neutral context; without *mo*, as in [Adam diim go chworō kom.].

- (10) a. Ma-kɔ **mo** Adam go chworō kom?
time-which FOC Adam slaughter fowl DEF
'When did Adam slaughter the fowl?'
- b. Adam go chworō kom [diim]_F **mo**.
Adam slaughter fowl DEF yesterday FOC
'Adam slaughtered the fowl YESTERDAY.'
- c. [Diim]_F **mo** Adam go chworō kom.
yesterday FOC Adam slaughter fowl DEF
'Adam slaughtered the fowl YESTERDAY.'
- (11) Adam [diim]_F **mo** go chworō kom.
Adam yesterday FOC slaughter fowl DEF
'Adam slaughtered the fowl YESTERDAY.'

2.2. Association with focus sensitive particle 'yerane'

The adfocal exclusive particle in Kasem is *yerane*. It follows the focus associate but precedes the focus particle *mo*. Just like the focus particle *mo*, *yerane* forms a constituent with the focus phrase both in an in-situ position (12-b) and an ex-situ position (12-c).

- (12) a. Did Adam slaughter a fowl and a cow yesterday?
- b. Adam go [chworō]_F **yerane mo** diim.
Adam kill fowl only FOC yesterday
'Adam slaughtered only A FOWL.'
- c. [Chworō]_F **yerane mo** Adam go diim.
fowl only FOC Adam kill yesterday
'It was only A FOWL that Adam slaughtered yesterday.'

In the preverbal position, association with subject focus also follows the same pattern as the association with object focus above. The focus associate cannot be separated from the focus sensitive particle (13-a). The same can be said of association with adjunct focus as well (13-b).

- (13) a. [Adam]_F ***(yerane) mo** go chworō (***(yerane)** diim (***(yerane)**).
Adam only FOC kill fowl only yesterday only
'Only ADAM slaughtered only a fowl.'
- b. Adam go chworō kom [diim]_F **yerane mo**.
Adam slaughter fowl DEF yesterday only FOC

‘Adam slaughtered the fowl only YESTERDAY.’

Kasem does not only possess an *adfocal-yerane* (adfocal-only), but also an adverbial or sentential *only* which is realized differently as *weeni* (14). Adverbial-*weeni* constructions are notable due to the presence of an obligatory ‘resumptive’ pronoun. The construction looks like a bi-clausal structure, but in the interest of space, I leave the analysis for a future research. For now, I will assume the simple structure in (15) for *weeni*-clauses.

- (14) Adam **weeni** *(o) go [chwor_o]_F **mo**.
Adam only 3SG kill.PFV fowl FOC
‘Adam only slaughtered A FOWL.’
- (15) [_{TP} Adam [_{VP} **weeni** [_{VP} o go [_{DP} [chwor_o]_F **mo**]]]]

Apart from the individual occurrences of the *adfocal-yerane* and the adverbial-*weeni* discussed above, the co-occurrence of both particles is also possible in Kasem (16); an unattested phenomenon in English (17).⁶ The reading in (16) is a single *only* reading which means that Adam only slaughtered a fowl and did not slaughter anything else. If he did, then the sentence in (16) is false. The same interpretation is derived with single-occurrence cases. This is a situation of form-meaning mismatch which has been discussed in the literature as evidence for a concord analysis (see Deal 2022, Penka 2011, Zeijlstra 2004, 2008 on Negative concord; Bayer 2018, 2020 on Discourse Particles (DiPs); Cable 2007, 2010 on question particles, among others).

- (16) Adam **weeni** *(o) go [chwor_o]_F **yerane mo**.
A. only 3SG kill.PFV fowl only FOC
‘Adam only slaughtered A FOWL.’
- (17) *Adam *only* killed *only* [a fowl]_F.

3. Evidence for the proposition approach

In this section, I will provide some evidence which supports the claim that the proposition approach, and not the quantifier-raising approach, best accounts for the association with *adfocal-yerane* in Kasem. First, I provide an evidence from the possibility of split-scope readings with *adfocal-yerane* (§ 3.1). Secondly, I show that the scope of the exclusive operator does not survive ellipsis; a prediction not made by the quantifier-raising approach (§ 3.2). Thirdly, I show how a prediction made by the proposition approach on the multiple occurrence of *adfocal-yerane* resulting in a single exclusive reading is borne out in § 3.3.

3.1. Scope ambiguity and split-scope reading

The proposition approach assumes the presence of a null operator (which can be overtly realized as the adverbial-*only*) which is responsible for the semantic contribution of exclusiveness. Therefore, the position of the operator must correspond to a scope-taking position. These positions include adjunction to the vP, TP, or even higher in the clausal spine; specifically, positions which correspond to proposition type (type *t*) (cf. Branan & Erlewine 2023, Hirsch 2022). However, since *adfocal-yerane* does not occupy such positions, but adjoins to DPs, PPs, it does not take scope in its surface position. This predicts the possibility of scope ambiguity in *adfocal-yerane* cases. This has already been observed by Taglicht (1984) in English whereby *adfocal-only* results in a scope ambiguity in a sentence like (18-a) and (18-b). The *adfocal-only* can either take narrow or broad scope with respect to the modal auxiliary and the higher predicate respectively. For instance, (18-a) could either be read as (i) John is allowed to only eat rice (but can eat other things too) (narrow scope) or (ii) John is only allowed to eat rice (no other allowance) (wide scope). The same thing happens in (18-b) where the *adfocal-only* and its associate can scope below or above the predicate *require*.

⁶ Other languages with *only*-doubling include Mandarin Chinese (Hole 2017, Sun 2021), Vietnamese (Erlewine 2017), i.a.

- (18) a. John may eat *only* rice. [may > only; only > may]
 (i) John is permitted to only eat rice and nothing else.
 (ii) John is only permitted to eat rice (no other permission).
 b. John is required to eat only rice. [require > only; only > require]
 (i) The requirement is for John to eat only rice (and nothing else).
 (ii) The only requirement is that John should eat rice (may eat other things).

3.1.1. Scope ambiguity in Kasem

Replicating such observation to Kasem results in scope ambiguity with respect to adfocal-*yerane* association with focus, and higher scopal operators like the modal and the higher predicate. In the presence of a higher predicate as in (19), or a modal auxiliary as in (20), adfocal-*yerane* and its focus associates *mumuna* ‘rice’ & *chworo* ‘fowl’ take both narrow and wide scope.

- (19) Adam **jeye** se o di [mumuna]_F **yerane mo**. [require > only; only > require]
 A. require to 3SG eat rice only FOC
 ‘Adam is required to eat only rice.’
 (i) The requirement is for Adam to eat only rice (and nothing else).
 (ii) The only requirement is that Adam should eat rice (may eat other things).
 (20) Adam **wae** *(o) go [chworo]_F **yerane mo**. [may > only; only > may]
 Adam may 3SG kill.PFV fowl only FOC
 ‘Adam may slaughter only A FOWL.’
 (i) It is acceptable for Adam to only slaughter a fowl.
 (ii) Adam is only allowed to slaughter a fowl (no other permission).

However, when the adverbial-*weeni* is present, the scope ambiguity disappears, as in (21). In this case, the overt position of the adverbial-*weeni* determines the scope relation with the higher predicate with or without the presence of the adfocal-*yerane*. Thus, adverbial-*weeni* can be below (21-a) or above (21-b) the higher predicate taking surface scope in relation to the latter.⁷ This is expected since adverbial-*weeni* occupies positions where it can take (surface) scope over a proposition. So, there is no ambiguity. Thus, the descriptive generalization is that *yerane* allows for scope ambiguities, whereas *weeni* is rigid in scope, reminiscent of what we find in English (cf. Branen & Erlewine 2023, Quek & Hirsch 2017). When both are present, the position of *weeni* determines the scope.

- (21) a. N **weeni** n **jeye** [se n ga [Bible dem]_F (**yerane**) **mo**].
 2SG only 2SG require to 2SG read Bible DEF only FOC
 ‘You are only required to read the Bible.’
 [*require > only; only > require]
 b. N **jeye** [se n **weeni** n ga [Bible dem]_F (**yerane**) **mo**].
 2SG require to 2SG only 2SG read Bible DEF only FOC
 ‘You are required to only read the Bible.’
 [require > only; *only > require]

Based on the discussion so far, the proposition approach is able to account for the scope ambiguity with respect to adfocal-*yerane* assuming a high exclusive operator in the clausal spine.

3.1.2. Split-scope in Kasem

Furthermore, following earlier works like Hirsch (2019, 2022), Lee (2005), Quek & Hirsch (2017), and Sun (2021), if adfocal-*yerane* takes a quantified DP associate, there is the possibility for a split in scope in relation with a high scope operator. This is an argument against adfocal-*yerane* and the associate taking scope together (the quantifier-raising approach). Here is how it works. Assuming we introduce a

⁷ Recall the presence of a pronoun in the *weeni*-clause in (14) above, here is another interesting case where the pronoun is repeated thrice in the context of a higher predicate. There seems to be a multiple clausal embedding in such structures. Again, I leave this for a future research.

scope bearing element (the numeral *bana* ‘four’ in this case) to the DP associate as in (22), the prediction of the proposition approach is that the latter should be able to scope independently of *adfocal-yerane* since both are scope-bearing elements. This is in fact borne out from the example in (22).⁸ The scope of the quantified DP is dissociated from the scope of *adfocal-yerane*. While *adfocal-yerane* (although low in the structure) can scope above the higher predicate, the quantified DP scopes below the latter, creating a split in the scope of both *adfocal-yerane* and the quantified DP.

- (22) Adam **jeye** se o swo kaana bana **yerane mo**. [only > require > four]
 Adam require to 3SG marry woman.PL four only FOC
 ‘(To be considered wealthy) Adam is required to marry *only* four wives.’
Meaning: Adam is only required to marry four wives (not specific).

This is an argument for the proposition approach because the scope position of *adfocal-yerane* is higher than its surface position. This confirms the presence of a covert exclusive operator (which provides the quantificational meaning) above the matrix predicate, as in (23). The quantifier-raising approach does not predict such a split in scope that we have seen. In the quantifier-raising approach, both *adfocal-yerane* plus the quantified DP associate would have to scope together, either above the embedded predicate (but below the matrix predicate) (24-a) or above the matrix predicate (24-b) (cf. Hirsch 2019). But this does not account for the split-scope that was just presented.

- (23) LF: [_{TP} Adam [Op_{only} [_{VP} **jeye** [se o [_{QP} kaana bana **yerane mo**]_i [_{VP} swo t_i]]]]].
 Adam require to 3SG woman.PL four only FOC marry
 ‘Adam is required to marry *only* four wives.’
- (24) a. LF: [_{TP} Adam **jeye** [_{TP} se o [_{QP} kaana bana **yerane mo**]_i [_{VP} swo t_i]]].
 Adam require to 3SG woman.PL four only FOC marry
 ‘Adam is required to marry *only* four wives.’
- b. LF: [_{TP} Adam [[_{QP} kaana bana **yerane mo**]_i [_{VP} **jeye** [_{TP} se o [_{VP} swo t_i]]]]].
 Adam woman.PL four only FOC req to 3SG marry
 ‘Adam is required to marry *only* four wives.’

3.2. Ellipsis

This section shows that while the proposition approach correctly derives the observed behaviour between Op_{only} and *adfocal-yerane* under ellipsis, the quantifier-raising approach, on the other hand, over-generates. This test was first used by Bassi et al. (2022) to argue in favour of the proposition approach to *adfocal-only* in English.

Beaver & Clark (2008: 177) observe that “*Only* and its associated Foc cannot be separated by a node targeted for ellipsis.” Bassi et al. (2022: 817) call this the ‘Beaver & Clark’s Constraint’. This is a constraint on the c-command relation between (adverbial) *only* and its focus associate. Consider the example in (25) (from Beaver & Clark 2008: p.177). The focus associate in the second clause [because Sandy ~~salute~~] is elided. The sentence cannot mean Sandy salutes and does nothing else because the exclusive particle *only* is separated from its associate by ellipsis. The latter requires that its focus associate is overtly present in its scope.⁹

- (25) *Kim *only* SALUTES because Sandy *only* does ~~salute~~.

⁸ The context used here is a typical cultural context where you are regarded as wealthy by the number of wives (and children) that you have. In order to get the split-scope reading, I had to create a context that is easily accessible to my language consultant.

⁹ See also the Principle of Lexical Association (PLA) by Tancredi (1990) in (i).

(i) **Principle of Lexical Association (PLA)**

An operator like *only* must be associated with a lexical constituent in its c-command domain.

(adapted from Tancredi 1990: 30)

[**cannot mean:** ‘Kim salutes (and does nothing else) because Sandy salutes (and does nothing else).’]

Bassi et al. (2022) gave a modified version of the constraint by Beaver & Clark (2008) in (26).

(26) **Proposition Approach version of B&C Constraint:**

Op_{only} and its associated Foc (adfocal-only) cannot be separated by a node targeted for ellipsis.

(adapted & modified from Bassi et al. 2022: p.819)

Recall that adfocal-*yerane* shows scope ambiguity in the presence of a modal. But in an ellipsis context (VP-ellipsis), the broad scope (and not the narrow scope) reading is absent (27). This is predicted by the proposition approach which assumes that the quantificational property of *only* resides in a high Op_{only} in the clausal spine (and not the adfocal-*yerane* itself). The narrow scope reading is available in (27) because both Op_{only} and adfocal-*yerane* are part of the ellipsis site (28-a). They are not separated by ellipsis. In contrast, we expect the broad scope reading to be absent if Op_{only} is now above the modal because it is now separated from its associate, as in (28-b).

(27) John **wae** o yeigi paano **yerane mo**. [Adam de wae o yeigi paano yerane mo].

John may 3sg buy bread only FOC Adam too may

‘John may buy only bread. Adam may ..., too.’

[may > only, *only > may]

(28) a. [T_P Adam de [T' wae [$\bar{V}P$ Op_{only} [$\bar{V}P$ o yeigi paano yerane mo]]]] too. [may > only]

b. *[T_P Adam de [T' Op_{only} [T' wae [$\bar{V}P$ o yeigi paano yerane mo]]]] too. [*only > may]

On the other hand, the quantifier-raising approach over-generates by predicting the possibility of a wide scope reading in a VP-ellipsis context, contrary to fact. The structures in (29) show that with the quantifier-raising approach, not only the narrow scope reading (29-a), but also the broad scope reading (29-b) is possible under ellipsis. While in (29-a), adfocal-*yerane* + DP quantifier-raises above VP, the same complex constituent QRs above the modal in (29-b). But we have seen that this is not the case with VP ellipsis in modal constructions (see (27) above): only the narrow scope reading is available. Thus, the proposition approach predicts correctly the behaviour of *only* in relation to other quantificational elements (like modal) under ellipsis.

(29) a. [T_P Adam de [T' **wae** [$\bar{V}P$ [paano yerane mo]_i [$\bar{V}P$ o yeigi t_i]]]] [may > only]

b. [T_P Adam de [[paano yerane mo]_i T' **wae** [$\bar{V}P$ [$\bar{V}P$ o yeigi t_i]]]] [only > may]

In summary, we have seen that while the quantifier-raising approach both under-generates in split-scope context and over-generates in ellipsis context, the proposition approach correctly predicts or derives the observed behaviours (cf. Bassi et al. 2022, Hirsch 2019, 2022).

3.3. Multiple occurrences of adfocal-*yerane*

The proposition approach predicts a situation where the multiple occurrence of adfocal-*yerane* can result in a single *only*-reading.¹⁰ Such an instance would have the interpretation dependent on Op_{only} , and not adfocal-*yerane*. The latter only performs the function of an agreement exponent (à la Lee 2005). This prediction is borne out in example (30). We can get the reading where Adam is the only person who ate

¹⁰This is in parallel to what we see in negative concord languages whereby multiple occurrences of n-words Agree with a high NEG-operator which results in a single negative reading. This is the case in Italian, a negative concord language. Zeijlstra (2007: p.513) argued that multiple occurrences of n-words in an example like (i) results in a single negative reading (cf. Zeijlstra 2004, 2006).

(i) Gianni non_[iNEG] ha detto niente_[uNEG] a nessuno_[uNEG]. Italian
Gianni neg has said n-thing to n-body
‘Gianni did not call anybody’

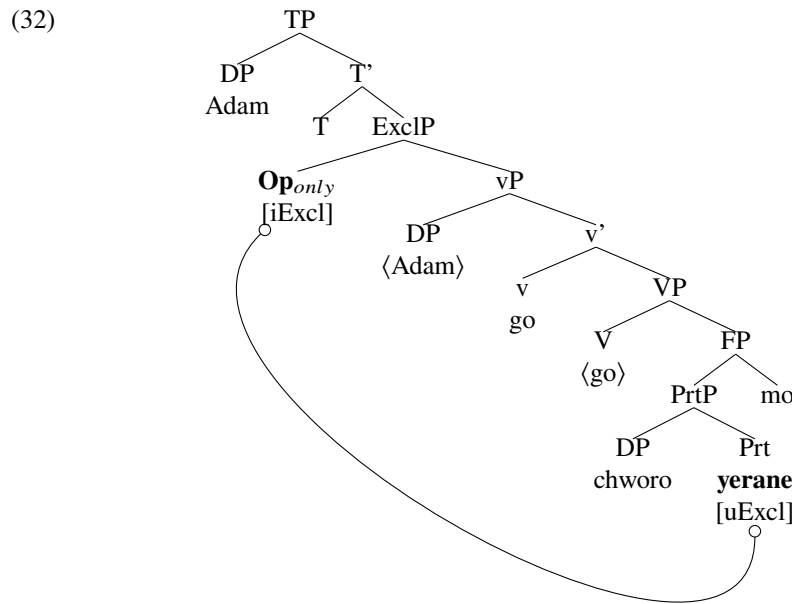
something, and that something is rice. Nobody else ate something, not even rice.¹¹ Without making special stipulations, it remains to be seen how the quantifier-raising approach would derive such an interpretation.

- (30) Adam **yerane** mo di mumuna **yerane**.
 Adam only FOC eat rice only
 Lit. ‘Only Adam ate only rice.’
 Reading: ‘It is the case that among those who could have eaten something, it is only Adam who ate something x , and x is rice.’

4. Analysis

I propose a bipartite analysis for adfocal-*yerane* in Kasem, following earlier works such as Bassi et al. (2022), Branan & Erlewine (2023), Lee (2005), Quek & Hirsch (2017), and Sun (2021), among others. Agreement establishes a link between the high exclusive operator, Op_{only} , and the adfocal-*yerane* lower in the clause. Consider the following structure in (32) for the simple focus sensitive sentence in (12-b), repeated below as (31) (without the adverb ‘yesterday’). The uninterpretable feature on adfocal-*yerane* Agrees with the interpretable feature on the exclusive null Op.¹² What Op_{only} does is that it determines the semantic scope of exclusivity.¹³

- (31) Adam go [chworō]_F **yerane** mo.
 Adam kill fowl only FOC
 ‘Adam slaughtered only A FOWL.’



The assumption is that the covert Op_{only} can occupy different positions in the clause as long as it takes a proposition (of type t) as one of its two semantic arguments (the other argument is the focus associate with its semantic value) (Rooth 1992). In other words, Op_{only} can adjoin to TP or vP as the case may be.

¹¹There is another reading which would indicate the presence of two Op_{only} . The reading would be a situation where only Adam ate only rice. There are others who ate other things including rice.

¹²The same Op_{only} is used by Branan & Erlewine (2023), and it is comparable to the abstract ONLY in Lee (2005), Quek & Hirsch (2017), and Hirsch (2022).

¹³Although previous accounts in this approach claim that the adfocal-particle is semantically inert (cf. Branan & Erlewine 2023, Lee 2005, Quek & Hirsch 2017, Sun 2021: a.o.), I leave that open in this study because there could be other focus-related function that adfocal-*yerane* is performing in the focus constructions.

We are left with the question about the relationship between *Op_{only}* and adverbial-*weeni*. I propose that when adverbial-*weeni* is present, it takes the role of *Op_{only}*. Unlike adfocal-*yerane*, we have seen that adverbial-*weeni* is scope-rigid and is always pre-verbal. Thus, we can say that *Op_{only}* can be overtly realized as *weeni*. But the distribution of adverbial-*weeni* is constrained to the pre-verbal position. But *Op_{only}* can have a wider distribution as it is predicted to be able to occur above TP for association with subject focus as in the example below (33).^{14 15} Another notable difference between *Op_{only}* and adverbial-*weeni* is the kind of structure that *weeni* introduces as shown already in the examples (14) and (16) above. As already mentioned above, I leave the proper analysis for such a structure for a future research.

- (33) **Op_{only}** [Adam]_F **yerane mo** go chworo diim.
 Adam only FOC kill fowl yesterday
 ‘Only ADAM slaughtered only a fowl.’

Therefore, in cases where only the adfocal-*yerane* occurs, we have agreement between it and *Op_{only}*. In doubling cases however, the agreement is between adfocal-*yerane* and adverbial-*weeni*.

5. Ex-situ focus and backward association

Finally, I discuss association with an ex-situ focus. This is interesting because there is a claim in the literature that *only* cannot associate backwards cross-linguistically (Beaver & Clark 2008, Erlewine 2014a,b, Jackendoff 1972: a.o.). In (34), while backward focus association is possible with *even* (34-a), the same is not true for *only* (34-b).¹⁶

- (34) a. [Mary]_F, John **even** saw at the party.
 b. *[Mary]_F, John **only** saw at the party.

(adapted from Erlewine 2014a: 129)

In a direct contrast, tentative results from Kasem show the possibility of backward association with adverbial-*weeni* in ex-situ focus constructions. Adverbial-*weeni* does not only associate with the in-situ object focus (35-a), but can also associate with the ex-situ counterpart (35-b). This is not possible in English as shown in (34-b) above. The exclusive interpretation in both (35-a) and (35-b) is the same: it is the case that Adam slaughtered only *x*, and *x* is a fowl. The presence of adfocal-*yerane* is optional.

- (35) a. Adam **weeni** o go [chworo]_F (yerane) **mo**.
 Adam only 3SG kill fowl only FOC
 ‘Adam only slaughtered A FOWL.’
 b. [Chworo]_F (yerane) **mo** Adam **weeni** o goa.
 fowl only FOC Adam only 3SG kill.COMPL
 Lit. ‘A FOWL, Adam only slaughtered. (and nothing else)’

Backward association with leftward subject focus is also possible in Kasem (36); a construction that does not result in a subject focus association in English (37) (cf. Erlewine 2014a, Jackendoff 1972).

- (36) Adam mo **weeni** o di mumuna.
 Adam FOC only 3SG eat rice
 ‘Only Adam ate rice.’
 (37) *[Adam]_F only ate rice.

The example in (38-b) shows that backward association is not clause bound, because it is also present in

¹⁴See Lee (2005) for a proposal of different positions for ONLY in Korean which depends on the case of the focus associate and the mirror principle.

¹⁵Another option is to assume that *Op_{only}* remains in the preverbal position since the subject externally merges within the vP (VP-internal hypothesis) before moving to Spec,TP.

¹⁶While previous studies (ibid.) focused more on *only*, and do not make it explicit whether other focus sensitive particles like *also* and *even* do not also associate backward, Erlewine (2014a,b) argues that only *only* does not associate backward in English, *even* does.

long distance dependencies. Both sentences in (38) have the same exclusive reading.

- (38) a. Adam we John **weeni** o go Chworo (yerane) mo.
Adam say John only 3SG kill fowl only FOC
Adam said that John only slaughtered A FOWL. (and nothing else)'
b. Chworo (yerane) mo Adam we John **weeni** o go.
fowl only FOC Adam say John only 3SG kill
Lit. 'A FOWL, Adam said that John only slaughtered. (and nothing else)'

The data presented above raises the question of whether *weeni* is truly a focus sensitive particle or not, considering the fact that true (conventional) focus sensitive particles are said to c-command their focus associates (cf. Beaver & Clark 2008, Rooth 1992, Tancredi 1990). But as we have seen so far, *weeni* is indeed a focus sensitive operator. How then do we reconcile the backward association cases with the c-command (scopal) requirement of *weeni*? A potential analysis, following Erlewine (2014a,b), is to assume reconstruction of the moved element to its base position. German and Dutch are two other languages with a similar observation. Both languages require movement to the clause-initial position because of their V2 properties. English, however, lacks such a property. For instance, an example like (39) shows that German allows backward association with *only*. Based on evidence from scope relations, Erlewine (2014b) argues for a reconstruction analysis for Dutch and German. I will not present this here for the want of space but see Erlewine (2014b: §7.4), and also Hirsch & Wagner (2019) for more discussions.

- (39) [Jedes BUCH] hat der Hans **nur** gelesen... (ZEITSCHRIFTEN hat er keine gelesen.)
every [book]_F has the Hans only read [magazines]_F has he none read
'It was only every BOOK that Hans read. He didn't read any MAGAZINES.'

(adapted from Erlewine 2014b: 188)

In any case, the data from Kasem suggests the need for a cross-linguistic research that might reveal more than we presently know on backward association with *only*. I will leave this for a future study on Kasem, and also languages with obligatory focus fronting.

6. Conclusion

In conclusion, this paper has provided a cross-linguistic support for the proposition approach to the analysis of adfocal-*only* from an under-researched language, Kasem. I have argued that in adfocal-*yerane* constructions, the exclusive interpretation does not originate from the focus particle itself, rather, the interpretation comes from a covert *Op_{only}* higher in the clause. Agreement establishes a link between *Op_{only}* and adfocal-*yerane*. Evidence from split-scope shows that the quantifier-raising approach under-generates the scopal possibilities since adfocal-*yerane* and its focus associate would have to always quantifier-raise together. In the ellipsis test on the other hand, the quantifier-raising approach over-generates as it predicts the possibility of a wide scope reading under ellipsis, contrary to fact (Bassi et al. 2022). On the other hand, the proposition approach, which requires the presence of *Op_{only}*, can deal with both cases. Therefore, this conclusion supports a growing body of research that argues for an *operator-particle* analysis for adfocal-*only* (see Branan & Erlewine 2023, Hole 2017, Lee 2005, Quek & Hirsch 2017, Sun 2021: among others).

Lastly, I presented cases of backward association. It is interesting to see that in Kasem not only do we see cases of backward association with *only* with respect to short ex-situ subject and non-subject, but also with long distance movement. The possibility of backward association in Kasem both reveals an interesting phenomenon and an area for further research.

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